



DRIVING AFFILIATE GROWTH FOR SMOKE CARTEL

COMPANY BACKGROUND

Smoke Cartel is an online headshop offering premium glass bongs, dab rigs, vaporizers, and smoking accessories. Founded by Sean and Darby in their apartment, the company set itself apart by partnering with American artists to provide quality, authentic products with faster shipping and customer-first service.

GOAL

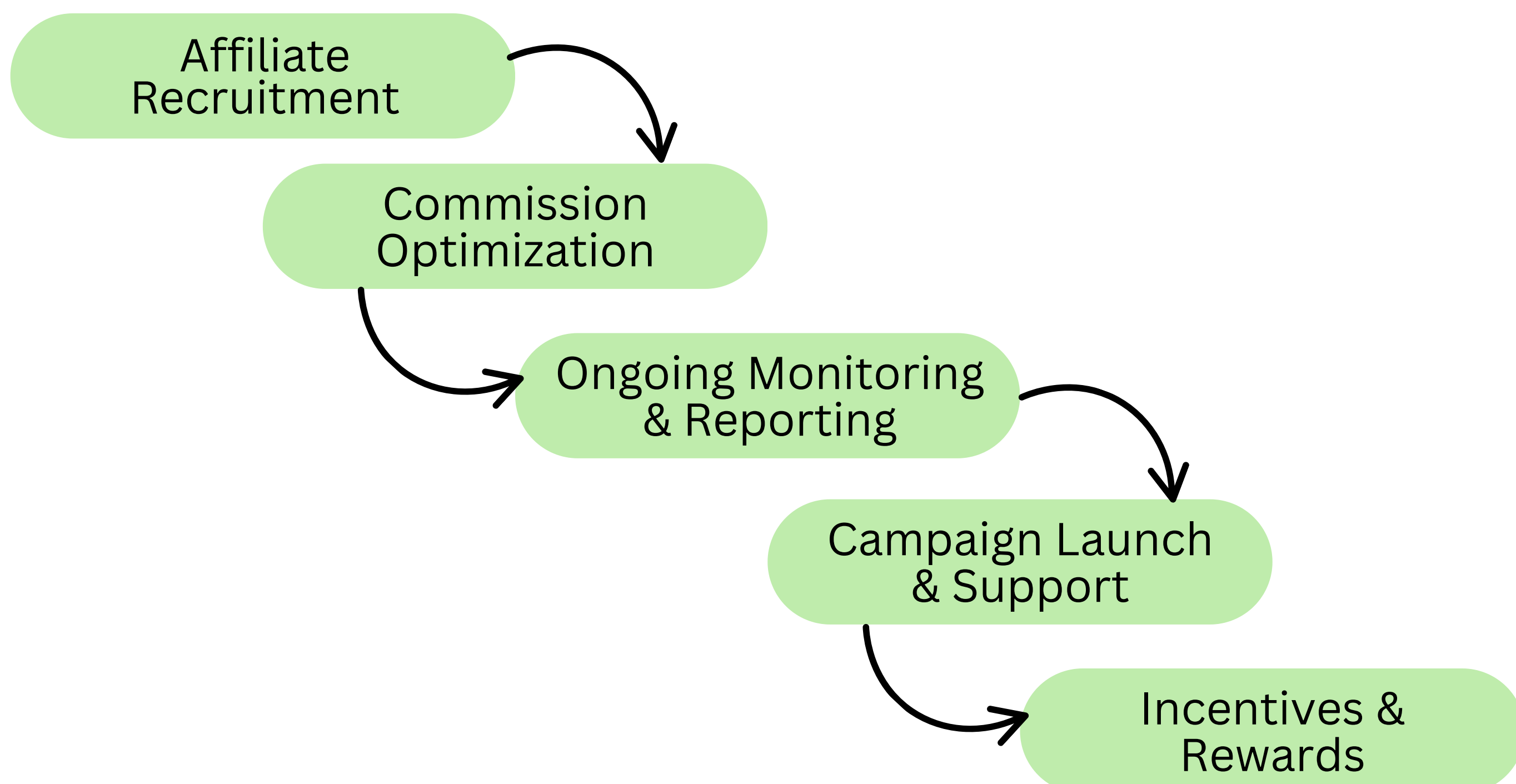
Smoke Cartel wanted to strengthen its presence in the affiliate marketing space. The goal was to expand its affiliate network and drive higher conversions through the ShareASale platform by partnering with the right affiliates and optimizing program performance.

STRATEGY

We implemented a structured affiliate management strategy focused on the following.

- Recruitment of affiliates – influencers, bloggers, and coupon partners.
- Optimized commissions & promotions – creating competitive offers for partners.
- Performance monitoring – tracking growth via the ShareASale dashboard.
- Affiliate support – providing partners with creatives, updates, and incentives.
- Incentivization – rewarding high-performing affiliates to sustain long-term growth.

EXECUTION



Through our affiliate management strategy, Smoke Cartel achieved consistent year-over-year growth on the ShareASale platform.

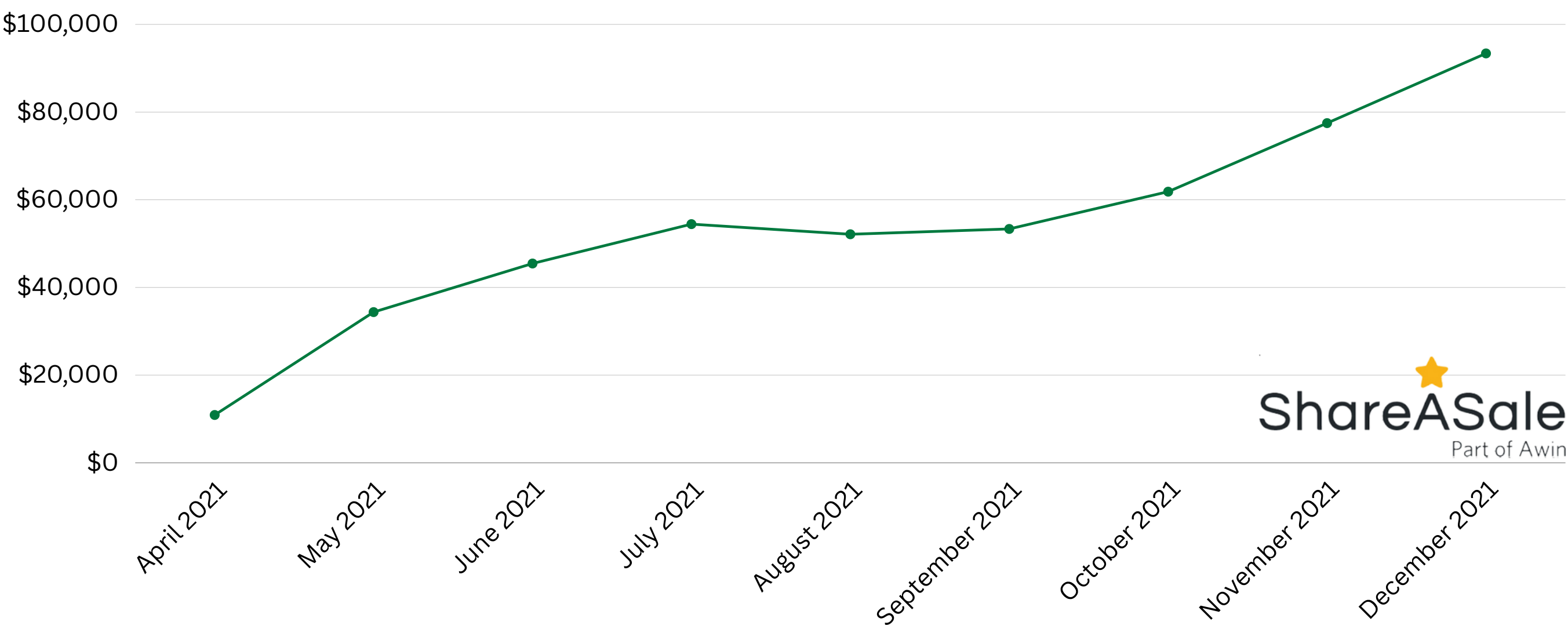


Figure 1. Monthly Gross Sales 2021

The affiliate program launched in April 2021, starting from zero and quickly gaining traction. It grew from 13 active affiliates in April to **85 active affiliates by November**, reflecting strong adoption and network expansion. Gross sales rose steadily, with July marking the **first major revenue spike**.

By December, monthly gross sales surpassed expectations, establishing a foundation for sustainable growth. This first year focused on recruiting partners and testing campaigns that shaped the program’s structure, with an **average monthly revenue of \$53,707**.

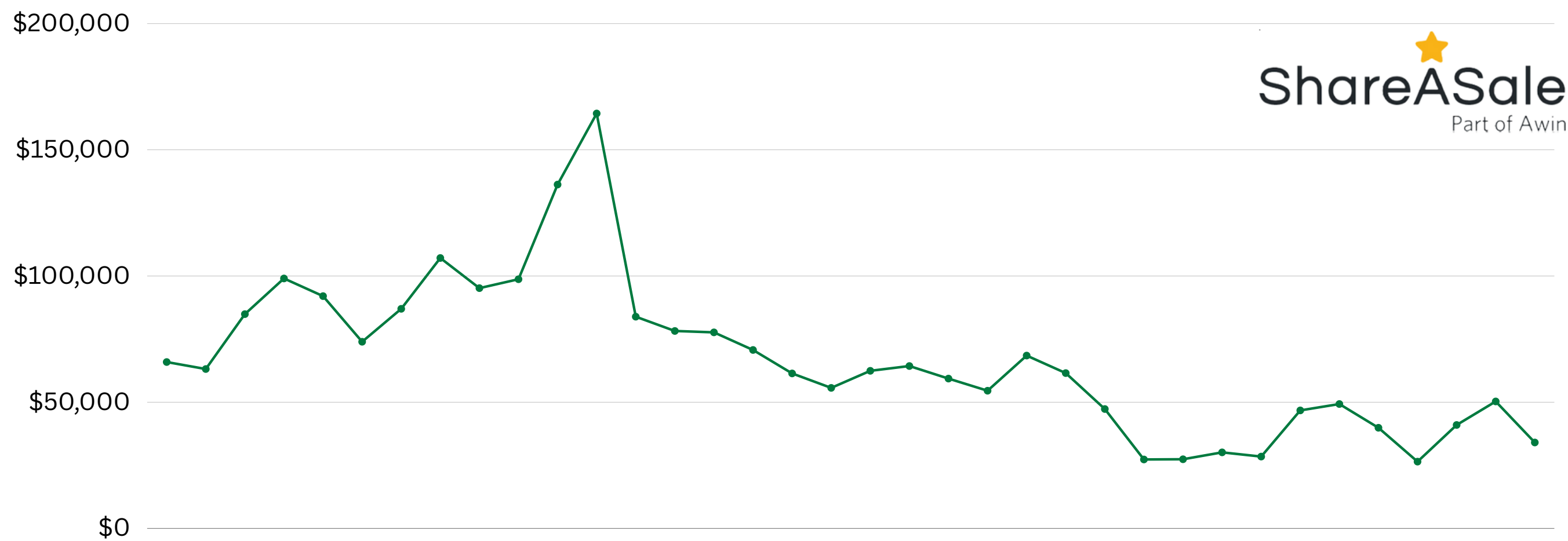


Figure 2. Monthly Gross Sales 2022 - 2024

In 2022, the program surpassed **\$1M in gross sales**, and nearly doubling the affiliate base compared to 2021. Monthly revenue **consistently reached \$35K–40K**, with strong seasonal surges in November and December, proving the scalability of the recruitment and optimization strategies.

Despite fewer affiliates than peak years, in 2024, the program maintained strong momentum, delivering **\$448K in gross sales and 6,851 transactions**. July 2024 marked the strongest single month (\$49,281 gross sales, 903 transactions), while high-engagement periods such as November (48,357 clicks) highlighted effective campaign timing and affiliate motivation.

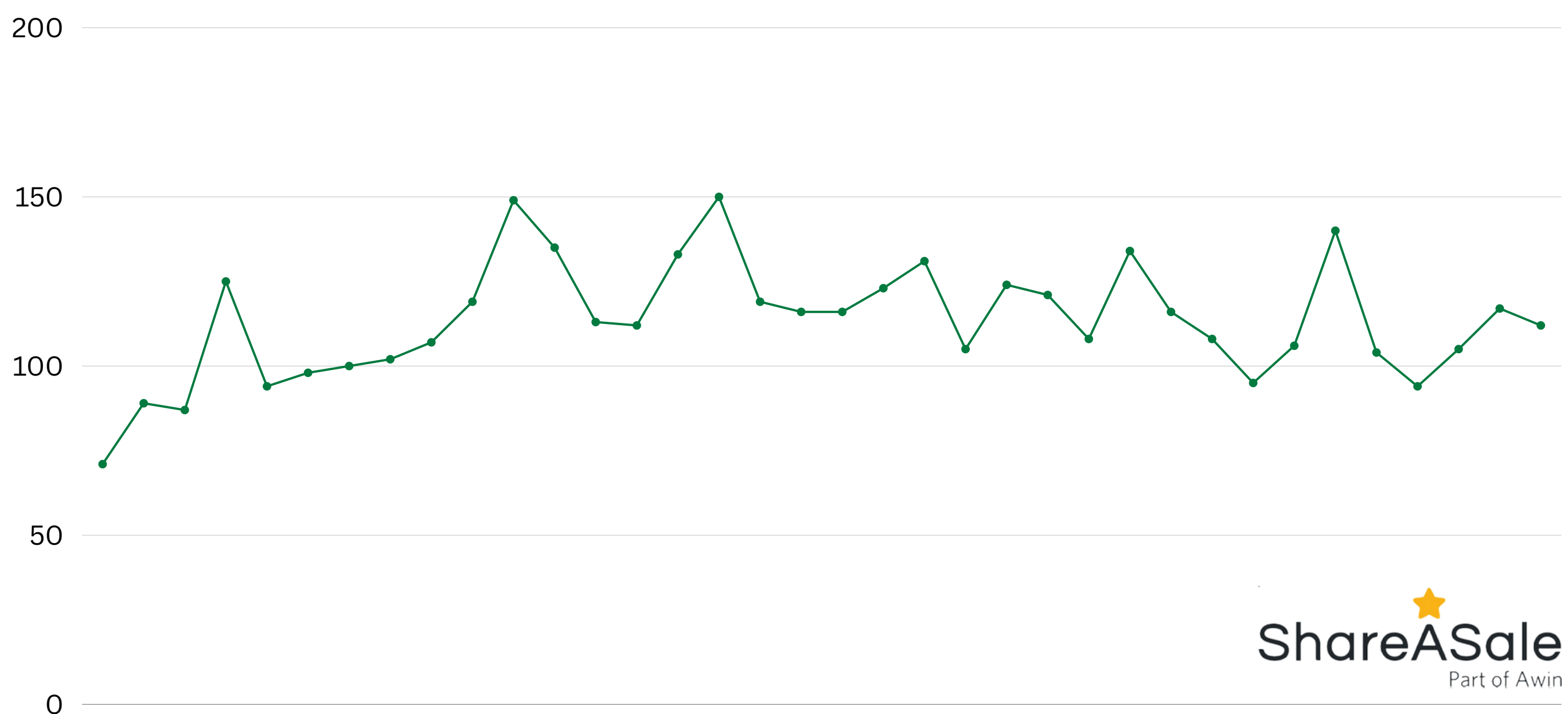


Figure 3. Monthly Active Affiliates 2022 - 2024

Affiliate growth that began in 2021 culminated in the program's highest engagement. In 2022, the program experienced breakthrough expansion, nearly doubling its network to **149 active affiliates by November** and generating over **524,000 engagements**.

In 2023, it reached peak engagement with **150 active affiliates in April**, demonstrating strong recruitment, retention, and partner trust, even as sales normalized. By 2024, the network stabilized between **94 and 140 active affiliates each month**, showing a mature, reliable ecosystem where consistency and partner quality outweighed rapid growth.

KEY TAKEAWAYS

Strategic recruitment expanded the network from 13 affiliates in 2021 to a peak of 150 in 2023. **Optimized commissions and well-timed seasonal promotions** drove major revenue spikes, highlighting the value of timing.

Incentives and clear communication built trust and retention, keeping affiliates engaged even during slower sales periods. **Consistent monitoring** enabled the program to surpass \$1M in sales by 2022 and sustain strong participation in the years that followed.

CONCLUSION

This case study highlights Smoke Cartel's structured approach on ShareASale transformed its affiliate channel into a reliable growth engine. From 13 affiliates at launch to \$1M+ in annual sales and 150 active partners at peak, the program demonstrated scalability, retention, and adaptability.

Even with fluctuations in revenue, sustained engagement proved its long-term value, showing how strategic recruitment, optimized promotions, and relationship management can turn an affiliate program into a durable, trusted revenue channel.